

HIGH-TECH CONSERVATION

To save its dwindling tiger population, Rajasthan has employed satellite tracking tools and beefed up security

■ By Rohit Parihar

Suddenly on July 19, without warning, Control Party 2, also called CP-2, disappeared off the face of the earth. Its disappearance sent the entire Wildlife Department into a tizzy because CP 2 was the wild tigress flown by the Indian Air Force from Ranthambore to the Sariska Wildlife Sanctuary as part of Project Reintroduction, an ambitious relocation plan aimed at giving Sariska

its big cats back. Ten days after she was moved, neither French satellite Argos tracking her via a 1.5-kg radio collar around its neck could trace it, nor could a team of 10 desperate foresters locate CP2. Even their handheld receivers, which could sniff its presence in a 2-km radius, did not beep. Forest officials were on the alert even as tiger CP-1, flown on June 27 and released just two days before the tigress, was spotted regularly, hunting prolifically and marking out its territory, often cover-

ing 10-12 km at a stretch.

After a long wait, R.N. Mehrotra, chief wildlife conservator, Rajasthan, noticed a flash on his LCD monitor at his Jaipur office on the morning of July 23. The satellite had finally sent a signal indicating the presence of the tigress in the 881-sq km Sariska. A signal was simultaneously received at the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), Dehradun, where K. Sankar, senior scientist had been monitoring tiger movement. Mehrotra immediately transposed the longitude and latitude coordinates of the tigress on Google Earth and located the tigress in a nullah. He called the foresters who discovered that the tigress had made a kill which she had dragged inside a shelter in a gorge, and this had hampered the collar's signals.

For the first time, the staff in Rajasthan is using modern technology—ground-based VHF as well as satellite detection communication tools—to track the wild cats. The satellite collar, which records data once in

HOUSE-WARMING: A relocated tiger with a collar around its neck

Photograph courtesy CHIEF WILDLIFE WARDEN, RAJASTHAN

